

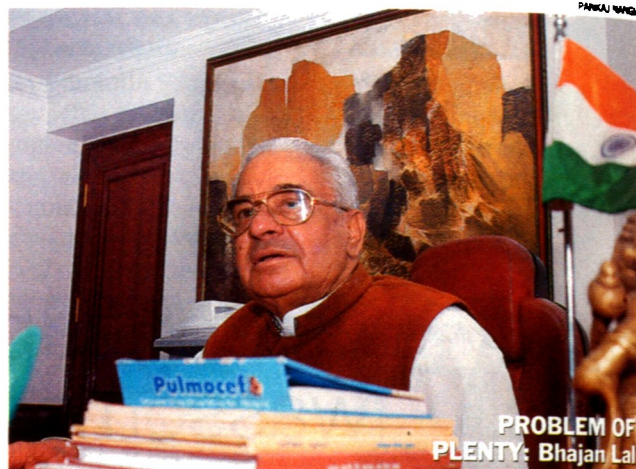
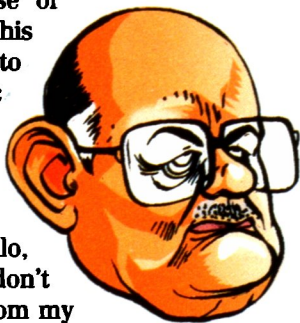
LOCOMOTIF S. PRASANNARAJAN

Arjun's Arrow



Being loyal and lonely is a terrible state of being for a Congressman who has spent a lifetime in servitude. Superannuated, superseded and what we in the media call "snubbed by Sonia", Arjun Singh at 77 is a study in the pathology of loyalty. Why has this man, a doddering doyen in the court of Gandhi, been forced to bare his soul and declare his unwavering faith in the ideal: "I would like to put it on record that when I met Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru in 1960, I pledged my total loyalty to him and his family. This was the commitment which is an article of faith with me. For the past 48 years of my life, I have scrupulously adhered to it"? Can't you feel the tremor of fear in those words, words that are spoken only to extend the speaker's irrelevance in the durbar of Madam Sphinx? Can't you make out that voice modulated by the twin forces of senescence and desperation? Only what he has not said can make sense of what he has said, and his leader who has refused to say hello to him at a public function ought to hear that. Excerpts from what Singh has not said:

"What's there for me to lose now? A *namaste*, a hello, a smile from the lady? I don't expect such courtesies from my leader any longer. Did I say leader? Ha! I accept her inevitability, I suffer her snub. And look at me, I even suffer her choice, that usurper at 7 Race Course Road. What's the ultimate snub, anyway? It happened four years ago, when she, after that soap operatic No at the Central Hall, looked through me, the original family retainer, and chose that technocrat as prime minister. It hurt. And it hurt my inner Nehru. Still I walked on, though it has never been let-by-gones-be-by-gones since then. I knew he, the dutiful prime minister, would not be setting the political agenda. He just can't. So I set the social agenda, and I was ready for the culture war. While others pushed files, I made history a disputed site. I took the sociology of governance to the ghettos of minorities, and I continue to be the last crusader of official secularism. There are people who say that the very name of my ministry is an Orwellian throwback, that, being the patron saint of reservation politics, I have divided the mind of India, that I'm a safari-suited Soviet specimen worthy of a permanent place in the museum. Call me whatever but spare a thought for this Congressman VSOP who has been upstaged by the neophytes who control the party—and the durbar. They can't control my mind. Hopefully I can."



Lal vs Lal vs Lal vs Lal

CHANDIGARH Call it a name game or a clever election strategy. In the high-stake by-election to the Adampur Assembly seat in Haryana slated for May 22, former Congress chief minister Bhajan Lal is facing five independents all of whom share his name and have been ostensibly fielded at the behest of the ruling Congress to dent his votebank.

Adampur has been Lal's family pocket borough since 1968, and has returned only Lal, his wife Jasman Devi and son Kuldeep Bishnoi in all 10

Assembly elections held in the past four decades. The official Congress candidate is Ranjit Singh, son of late Devi Lal, but the party has set the cat among the pigeons by fielding five candidates, all named Bhajan Lal. Worse for the real Lal, the Haryana Janhit Congress, a break-away party floated by him and his MP son Bishnoi was denied its choice of election symbol—the rising sun. Lal is contesting on the symbol of a lamp post. It may, thus, prove too greasy for the real Lal.

by Ramesh Vinayak

Road to Vastu

MUMBAI When all else fails, turn to God and pray that everything works out. At least this is what the disbelievers will say of the Nagpur police's latest road safety venture. Unable to check the growing number of accidents, the rural police are now relying on vastu shastra for divine intervention. Vastu expert Sushil Fatepuria, with the help of the police, has installed 12 vastu pyramids in accident prone zones to reduce "negative

energies" and improve the "vibes" of the area. Superintendent of Police Yashasvi Yadav feels the results are encouraging. Since November, no fatal accidents have been reported at these spots. He, however, concedes that there is no scientific explanation for the experiment and explains that his team has stepped up conventional policing measures also. With stringent policing and a helping hand from vastu experts, Nagpur's roads might just become safer. by Aditi Pal